

PART 8: DUNGEON MASTER INFORMATION

Before players can take their characters on adventures into dungeons, the DM must either create a dungeon or draw its map, or become familiar with one of TSR's dungeon modules. The "B" series of modules is designed for use with the D&D BASIC SET. The module included in this set may be used to start adventuring immediately, and will provide some ideas for designing dungeons.

This section gives a step-by-step guide to creating a dungeon. The guide is followed by an example of part of a dungeon level. The example follows the same steps as the guide and illustrates each step. A set of suggested symbols is included for DMs to use when drawing a dungeon map.

The same level is only part of a larger dungeon. The sample tower may be used to practice adventuring, and the dungeon outline may be useful if the DM wants to finish the dungeon.

A. CHOOSE A SCENARIO.

A scenario is a background theme or idea which ties the dungeon together. A scenario will help keep a dungeon from becoming a boring repetition of "open the door, kill the monster, take the treasure". A good scenario always gives the players a reason for adventuring. The DM should also design a dungeon for the levels of characters who will be playing in it. A good scenario will also give the DM a reason for choosing specific monsters and treasures to put in the dungeon.

A scenario may be anything the DM can imagine. To help new DMs, some common scenarios are listed below and explained. The DM can fill in the details.

Scenarios

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|------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 1. Exploring the Unknown | 6. Fulfilling a Quest |
| 2. Investigating a Chaotic Outpost | 7. Escaping from Enemies |
| 3. Recovering Ruins | 8. Rescuing Prisoners |
| 4. Destroying an Ancient Evil | 9. Using a Magic Portal |
| 5. Visiting a Lost Shrine | 10. Finding a Lost Race |

1. Exploring the Unknown: The party is hired to map unknown territory. The area might once have been familiar but is now overrun or destroyed; a strange tower might mysteriously appear overnight in a familiar area. Dungeon modules **B1 (In Search of the Unknown)** and **B3 (Palace of the Silver Princess)** are examples of exploration scenarios.

2. Investigating a Chaotic Outpost: This scenario has to do with a Chaotic invasion (either in progress or about to begin). The characters must enter the enemy outpost, find out the strength and plans of the invaders, and destroy the outpost if possible. Dungeon module **B2 (The Keep on the Borderlands)** is an example of this type of scenario.

3. Recovering Ruins: The party is usually scouting an old village before permanent settlers move in. The ruins have often been overrun by a specific kind of monster which must be killed or driven away. The ruins could be part of (or underneath) a thriving town!

4. Destroying an Ancient Evil: The evil is usually a monster or NPC (the exact type not known by the players). Sometimes the evil has been deeply buried and re-awakened by recent digging. This theme is often used along with others; for example, an ancient evil may have to be destroyed before some ruins are resettled.

5. Visiting a Lost Shrine: To remove a curse or recover a sacred item, the players must travel to a shrine which has

been lost for ages. The characters usually have only a rough idea of its location. The players may have to consult an oracle or seer during their visit.

6. Fulfilling a Quest: This is a scenario in which a king (or other NPC) provides a reason for adventuring. A variation of this is a special mission for "the gods". Quite often this scenario also involves the recovery of a sacred object or powerful magic item.

7. Escaping from Enemies: The player characters begin this adventure as prisoners, and must escape. The reason is clear and simple, especially if imprisonment is to be followed by the deaths of the characters. The DM must be careful to make escape possible (though not necessarily easy).

8. Rescuing Prisoners: Valuable and important persons are being held prisoners by bandits, a tribe of orcs, or an evil magic-user. The party sets out to rescue the prisoners because they have been hired to (for an expected reward), for a debt of honor, or for some other reason. Sometimes the player characters are only hired to guard an individual who is talking over the demands for ransom. This scenario is the basis for the sample dungeon hereafter (The HAUNTED KEEP).

9. Using a Magic Portal: The "magic portal" is a device which magically sends creatures from one place to another. A magic portal is usually a door into another dimension or world, and thus may easily become the point of an invasion from one of these worlds. Portals may be known or secret. If known, the characters may be on a mission to destroy or guard a portal used by enemies, or perhaps to reopen or repair a "closed" portal. Secret portals can be used to make sure that the characters will visit an important area of a dungeon. Portals might operate both ways, or one way only (teleporting into but not out of an area).

10. Finding a Lost Race: The players find a once-human race which has lived underground for so long that it has begun to change. Its members might have developed infravision, changed color, or begun to fall back into animal ways. This scenario works well when used with **Destroying an Ancient Evil**, since Lost Races are often servants of the ancient powers. This scenario requires extra work and imagination by the DM, since details for the Lost Race must be invented.

B. DECIDE ON A SETTING.

It is not necessary to draw a detailed map of the dungeon first, but it is useful to have a *general* idea of what it will look like. When deciding on the shape of the dungeon, the DM should also outline ideas for rooms or areas in the dungeon. A few common settings include:

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| 1. Castle or tower | 4. Crypt or tomb |
| 2. Caves or cavern | 5. Ancient temple |
| 3. Abandoned mine | 6. Stronghold or town |

C. DECIDE ON SPECIAL MONSTERS TO BE USED.

The DM should decide on what special monsters (not placed by using the **Wandering Monster** tables) will be used. Some monsters should be placed by the DM because of the scenario chosen, and the DM may create or change some monsters to fit the dungeon.